

Patronage: The Economy Behind Grace

Before grace was a doctrine, charis was a word for what benefactors gave and what recipients owed. Paul knew the system. He also broke it.

THE SYSTEM

An Economy of Favors

The Roman world had no safety net. No insurance, no loans at fair interest for ordinary people, no public relief worth the name. What it had was patronage. A person of means granted favors, grain in a famine, a loan, legal protection, access to power, and the recipient entered a standing relationship of obligation. The client owed gratitude, public honor, loyalty, service. Not as a quiet feeling. As a social debt everyone could see.

This was not a corner of the culture. It was the culture. The philosopher Seneca wrote a whole treatise, *On Benefits*, calling the exchange of favors the practice that most holds human society together. And the worst man in that world was not the thief. It was the ingrate, the man who took a gift and gave no return of honor. Seneca ranked ingratitude among the gravest of social crimes.

Every reader of the New Testament lived inside this web. Patron and client, benefactor and city, god and worshiper. Gifts created bonds. Nobody thought otherwise.

THE WORD

Grace Already Worked for a Living

The Greek word *charis*, the word our Bibles translate as grace, was the working vocabulary of this system. It carried three senses at once, and the same word covered all three. *Charis* was the disposition of a generous giver. *Charis* was the gift itself. And *charis* was the gratitude the recipient returned. Favor given, favor received, thanks returned, one word for the whole circle.

David deSilva has shown how thickly this language covers the inscriptions of the period. Cities voted public thanks to benefactors, recorded their *charis* in stone, and promised to remember. To receive *charis*

and return nothing was not a private failing. It was a breach of the order that held the world together.

So when Paul writes that by *charis* you have been saved, his first readers did not hear an abstraction from a theology textbook. They heard the most familiar word in their social vocabulary. They heard benefaction. And they instinctively asked the question the system trained them to ask. What does the recipient now owe.

THE USE

Paul Speaks the Language

Paul does not stand outside this economy throwing stones. He works within it. He calls Phoebe a *prostatis*, a patron, of many and of himself, and asks the Roman church to receive her in a manner worthy of that standing. He organizes a large collection from Gentile churches for the poor in Jerusalem and frames the whole project in the language of *charis*, gift answering gift. He tells the Corinthians that the Lord Jesus Christ, though he was rich, became poor for their sake, so that by his poverty they might become rich. That is benefaction language. Christ is presented as the great benefactor, and the church as the community of his beneficiaries.

Even Paul's constant thanksgivings follow the pattern. Returning honor to a benefactor was the first duty of anyone who had received a gift, and Paul's letters open with it again and again.

The New Testament does not apologize for this framework. It assumes it. Which means we misread grace when we strip it out of the world of gift and return and place it in a world of contracts and consumer choice. Our world, not theirs.

THE BREAK

The Gift Without Regard to Worth

Here is where Paul breaks the system, and John Barclay's book *Paul and the Gift* has mapped the break with care. In the ancient world, a wise giver gave to worthy recipients. Gifts were targeted. You benefited people whose character, status, or gratitude made them fitting objects of your generosity. Giving to the unworthy was not noble. It was waste, and the moralists said so.

Paul announces a gift given without regard to worth. Christ died for the ungodly. God justifies not the deserving but the one who does not work. The gift lands on Jew and Gentile, slave and free, the fitting and the unfit, precisely without reference to their fittingness. Barclay calls this the incongruity of grace, the perfect mismatch between the worth of the recipient and the size of the gift.

That was the scandal. Not that God gives. Every god gave. The scandal was who receives. A gift with no entry requirements offended a world built on giving to the deserving. It still offends. I notice this in myself whenever grace lands on someone I had quietly filed as unworthy.

THE WEIGHT

Free Grace Still Obligates

Now the correction our own age needs. We hear the word free and think no strings attached, a gift we can pocket and walk away from. No first-century reader thought that. A gift without prior conditions was still a gift that created a relationship, and a relationship carried expectations. Barclay puts it sharply. Paul's grace is unconditioned, given without regard to worth, but it is not unconditional, as if nothing were expected after. The gift transforms the recipient and calls forth a returned life.

This is why Paul can say you were saved by grace apart from works and then, in the same breath, that you were created for good works. It is why Romans spends eleven chapters on the gift and then says therefore, present your bodies as a living sacrifice. The return is not repayment. No client ever repaid a patron, and no creature repays God. The return is gratitude with a body on it.

Not a contract. A bond. We have preached a grace that asks nothing because we confused freedom with detachment, and the first century knew better. The gift is free. The gift is also binding. Both sentences are good news, and the second one is the one we keep losing.

KEY TEXTS

Romans 4:4-5

Ephesians 2:8-10

2 Corinthians 8:9

SOURCES

Paul and the Gift — John M. G. Barclay

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva

Paul's Language of Grace in Its Graeco-Roman Context — James R. Harrison

Backgrounds of Early Christianity — Everett Ferguson